

library of patchouli - human

no longer human -- osamu dazai

7/10

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i have little inkling of what this book is really about. i could only attempt to fathom. the persona, yozo, slowly descends into self-deprecation and self-loathe by alienating himself from the "outside world". he first plays the role of an actor in a comedy show, then unassociates himself from society by finding the differences in thought between him and those around him. he seems to be overly analytic and his precocity has drawn much unwarranted troubles to him at an early age.

he repeatedly mentions he cannot refuse offers from people and also does everything in his power to please those around him. he mentions it is due to a terminal fear of something. was it "society" and the pressure surrounding that? or was it not fitting in ?

my honest feeling is that he started out on a wrong path and having had no one to talk to him about it early on, he went on to stray himself and reinforce his decision to ostracise himself from the crowds. this isolation grew with the vices and fuelled his subsequent self loathing.

venus says this straying of the path could be possibly due to the sexual abuse he experienced as a child. i dont remember much about the front parts so i cannot ascertain as well.

his true self is exposed multiple times throughout his life and each time it has made him grow increasingly anxious: the guy pointing out his faked fall in school; the policeman pointing out his faked bleed-coughing. whatever

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"Another thing I found fascinating is the massive amount of Dazai's autobiographical elements. Like Yozo, Dazai neglected his studies and took interest in Marxism, prostitutes and alcohol. Both were born in privileged families and felt guilt about it. Both attempted suicide by drowning off a beach in Kamakura with young bar hostesses. Both Yozo and Dazai survived, and both women died. Both became addicted to morphine-based painkillers. At the end, Dazai committed suicide by drowning. Yozo's whereabouts remain unknown, although he might have done the same thing."

~ <https://byronsmuse.wordpress.com/2017/02/02/book-review-no-longer-human-by-osamu-dazai/>

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book is filled with words i am uncertain about. thanks to this i have inflated my word bank to more than double its original length. hope i will continue to do that in the future.

now heres some phrases and parts that i found particularly profound

sin count: 2 surprisingly

> God, I ask you. Is trustfulness a sin?

> God, I ask you, is non-resistance a sin?

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> Again he is smiling, this time not the wizened monkey's grin but a rather adroit little smile. And yet somehow it is not the smile of a human being: it utterly lacks substance, all of what we might call the "heaviness of blood" or perhaps the "solidity of human life"—it has not even a bird's weight. It is merely a blank sheet of paper, light as a feather, and it is smiling.

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> The picture has a genuinely chilling, foreboding quality, as if it caught him in the act of dying as he sat before the camera, his hands held over a heater.

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> Mine has been a life of much shame.

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the persona seems to be unimpressed by human everyday facilities and ideas. once he realises the trains and railway bridges are not for novelty he loses all interest

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he doesnt experience hunger at all. detachment

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> Why must human beings eat three meals every single day? What extraordinarily solemn faces they all make as they eat! It seems to be some kind of ritual. Three times every day at the

regulated hour the family gathers in this gloomy room. The places are all laid out in the proper order and, regardless of whether we're hungry or not, we munch our food in silence, with lowered eyes.

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> Women found in me a man who could keep a love secret.

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> Some nights I saw these imbecile, lunatic prostitutes with the halo of Mary.

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> The severest apprenticeship in women, they say, is with prostitutes, and that makes it the most effective. The odor of the "lady-killer" had come to permeate me, and women (not only prostitutes) instinctively detected it and flocked to me. This obscene and inglorious atmosphere was the "bonus" I received, and it was apparently far more noticeable than the recuperative effects of my apprenticeship.

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> He seemed so simple and straightforward that I let down my guard completely. I was listlessly recounting my story when suddenly I was seized with another fit of coughing. I took out my handkerchief. The blood stains caught my eye, and with ignoble opportunism I thought that this cough might also prove useful. I added a couple of extra, exaggerated coughs for good measure and, my mouth still covered by the handkerchief, I glanced at the district attorney's face.

> The next instant he asked with his quiet smile, "Was that real?"

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> Even now the recollection makes me feel so embarrassed I can't sit still. It was worse, I am sure, even than when in high school I was plummeted into hell by that stupid Takeichi tapping me on the back and saying, "You did it on purpose." Those were the two great disasters in a lifetime of acting. Sometimes I have even thought that I should have preferred to be sentenced to ten years imprisonment rather than meet with such gentle contempt from the district attorney.

he is an actor caught in the act

the thin paper veil between him and the human world has been poked through and they "see his true colours". and he is extremely unprepared

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> The boy almost always prepared the food in Flatfish's house, and three times a day he would carry on a separate tray meals for the parasite on the second floor.

he now refers to himself in third person. detachment?

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> For about a week I remained in a state of daze. Just outside the apartment window was a kite caught in the telegraph wires; blown about and ripped by the dusty spring wind, it nevertheless clung tenaciously to the wires, as if in affirmation of something. Every time I looked at the kite I had to smile with embarrassment and blush. It haunted me even in dreams.

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> The undrunk glass of absinthe.

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> I was frightened even by God. I could not believe in His love, only in His punishment. Faith. That, I felt, was the act of facing the tribunal of justice with one's head bowed to receive the scourge of God. I could believe in hell, but it was impossible for me to believe in the existence of heaven.

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> I was taken aback. Horiki at heart did not treat me like a full human being. He could only consider me as the living corpse of a would-be suicide, a person dead to shame, an idiot ghost.

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> Imagine saying that the law was the antonym of crime! But perhaps everybody in "society" can go on living in self-satisfaction, thanks to just such simple concepts. They think that crime hatches where there are no policemen.

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> "You can't be serious. The antonym of crime is virtue. A virtuous citizen. In short, someone like myself."

> "Let's not joke. Virtue is the antonym of vice, not of crime."

> "Are vice and crime different?"

> "They are, I think. Virtue and vice are concepts invented by human beings, words for a morality which human beings arbitrarily devised."

> "What a nuisance. Well, I suppose it is God in that case. God. God. You can't go wrong if you leave everything at God . . . I'm hungry."

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> Then I made an utterly unpremeditated slip of the tongue, one so comic, so idiotic that it all but defies description. I said, "I'm going somewhere where there aren't any women."

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> Even if released, I would be forever branded on the forehead with the word "madman," or perhaps, "reject."

> Disqualified as a human being.

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> **Now I have neither happiness nor unhappiness.**

> **Everything passes.**

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> Some parts are rather exaggerated I can tell, but you obviously suffered a hell of a lot at his hands. If everything written in these notebooks is true, I probably would have wanted to put him in an insane asylum myself if I were his friend."

> "It's his father's fault," she said unemotionally. "The Yozo we knew was so easy-going and amusing, and if only he hadn't drunk—no, even though he did drink—he was a good boy, an angel."

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